

THE MICHAEL THORNE SERIES - BOOK SIX

The Unseen Trial

A Psychological Crime Thriller

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READING SAMPLE

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About this reading sample

This reading sample contains a continuous excerpt from the beginning of *The Unseen Trial*. It is based on the edition identified on the cover. The text below is drawn from the manuscript and is not the complete book.

Excerpt length: approximately 5,624 words.

PROLOGUE

THE FIRST VERDICT

* * *

Pete Davidson learned that Dr. Owen Markham was dead from a television above the counter of a twenty-four-hour diner in Rogers Park.

The reporter stood outside the medical building with her coat closed to the throat and the word CURATOR printed beneath her in white capitals.

Police had not used the word.

The station had.

Pete watched without turning his head fully towards the screen.

A plate of eggs cooled in front of him. The waitress had filled his coffee twice and stopped asking whether he wanted anything else.

Markham's photograph appeared beside an old image of Michael Thorne entering Meridian Gallery.

The gallery photograph had already been proved misleading.

The station used it anyway.

Pete understood why.

A corrected image required explanation. A familiar image required only repetition.

The reporter said Michael remained under continuous observation and could not have entered the clinic during the estimated time of death. She did not call that exoneration. She called it a development.

The word was careful.

The screen beneath it was not.

Pete lifted the coffee.

His right palm did not touch the cup.

Three hours earlier, he had pressed that hand beneath a photocopied case abstract on Markham's printer tray.

Not accidentally.

He had wanted the laboratory to find something that did not belong to Michael.

He had not wanted them to find enough.

A partial print created procedure.

A complete print created an arrest.

Procedure gave the reader time.

The broadcast moved to the courthouse where barriers had already been placed for the opening of United States v. Michael James Thorne. The trial had been delayed by sealed archives, competing custody claims and evidence that belonged to more than one jurisdiction. Tomorrow, the first jury panel would enter through a protected side door.

Michael would sit where every movement could be seen.

Pete had once believed visibility produced truth.

Four years beside Michael's work had taught him otherwise.

Visibility produced a record.

Someone still decided what the record meant.

The waitress placed the bill face down beside his plate.

"Take your time."

Pete nodded.

He waited until she moved to the other end of the counter before opening the brown document envelope inside his coat.

The original seal had been cut by the federal laboratory.

The contents inside were copies.

Seven case abstracts.

A blank badge photographed from both sides.

Michael's letter.

Pete had received the copies through discovery because the envelope had been recovered from his locker and his conduct remained under administrative review. His attorney believed the documents helped him. They proved the seal had been intact. They proved he had not read the instructions before surrendering the packet.

They did not prove when he first understood what Michael had built around him.

Pete removed the first abstract.

DR. OWEN MARKHAM.

The accusation appeared in twelve lines.

The clearance appeared nowhere.

A separate review team had later attached the pharmacy audit showing Markham did not divert controlled medication. Pete had read that audit too.

He had left it open on the clinic computer.

He wanted the room to contain both versions.

Not because innocence had stopped him.

Because the decision meant nothing if only one version existed.

Markham had prescribed sedatives to officers whose names appeared in Ascension records. He had noticed injuries

inconsistent with their reports. He had accepted explanations that protected careers and returned men to duty.

None of that proved he supplied a murder.

None of it made him responsible for what those officers later did.

Markham had told himself the same thing during the final minutes.

Pete had listened.

The doctor's fear had not changed the file.

His explanation had.

Pete had expected denial.

Markham gave context.

Context was the part Michael always said institutions removed first.

Pete had almost left.

Then Markham asked whether Michael had sent him.

Not whether the police had.

Not whether a victim's family had.

Michael.

The name entered the room as authority even while its owner sat behind locked doors.

Pete understood then that walking away would not end the method.

It would only return the choice to people who had already decided that Markham's clearance closed the question.

He applied the patch beneath the doctor's ear.

He waited until Markham could no longer lift his right arm.

Then he arranged the room.

The arrangement was not identical to Michael's work.

It was more legible.

That was deliberate.

Michael made scenes for investigators who had not yet learned the language.

Pete made one for investigators who believed they already knew it.

The reporter on the television said no suspect had been identified.

Pete folded the first abstract and returned it to the envelope.

The second concerned Naomi Sloane.

Records supervisor.

Corrected death certificates.

Private copies preserved after the correction programme closed.

The abstract described the first two facts.

It omitted the third.

Pete had not chosen her because Michael listed her.

He chose her because the court intended to use her preservation work as proof that independent evidence could survive Michael's control.

That conclusion was incomplete.

Naomi had preserved documents only after three children had already disappeared from the official record.

She had saved proof.

She had not saved them.

The law would call that distinction unfair.

Pete called it the question.

He turned Michael's letter over.

The final paragraph had been underlined by the laboratory in blue pencil.

Do not treat an allegation as proof because the system failed to test it. Do not treat institutional failure as proof that no act occurred. The reader's task is not punishment. It is to decide what can be preserved when every available route produces a different official truth.

Michael had written that remove could refer to access.

Michael had also written that sometimes a person held the access.

Pete did not need permission.

He needed a standard.

Outside, a bus pushed dirty water against the kerb.

The television showed Michael entering court during an earlier hearing. Dark suit. White shirt. Hands visible. No pocket watch.

The image stopped before he sat down.

Pete placed cash beneath the cup.

He left the diner at 6:31.

His suspended police badge remained in his attorney's safe.

The medical courier credential had already been cut into six pieces and dropped into separate public bins.

The black card from Markham's chest would enter evidence before noon.

The next card remained blank.

Pete carried it inside his coat with Naomi Sloane's abstract.

The court would begin trying Michael in public.

Pete had already begun trying the people the record allowed the court not to see.

CHAPTER 1

THE DEFENDANT WHO COULD NOT BE THERE

* * *

The first day of Michael Thorne's trial began with a murder the jury was not permitted to know had happened.

Judge Solis stated the rule before the first panel entered.

"The death of Dr. Owen Markham is the subject of a separate investigation. It is not evidence that the defendant committed or did not commit any charged act. Counsel will not refer to it during selection, opening statements or witness examination without prior permission."

The lead prosecutor stood.

"The government understands."

Price stood beside Michael.

"The defence understands and reserves its position if the government later argues continuation, common method or consciousness of guilt."

"Reserved. Not decided."

"Yes, Your Honour."

Michael remained seated.

The courtroom had been altered for the trial.

A second camera covered the defence table. A deputy stood behind each exit. The public gallery had fewer seats because

two rows had been removed to create distance around witnesses entering from the protected corridor.

The pocket watch remained in evidence.

Michael's hands rested on a yellow legal pad.

He had drawn no line across it.

Elena watched from the witness room feed.

Her recusal order prevented her from joining the prosecution table. Her role in the Markham investigation was narrower still. She could transmit verified facts between the independent homicide team and the protected-candidate unit. She could not direct the scene, question Pete or decide whether any new evidence entered Michael's case.

The boundaries frustrated everyone who wanted one person to connect the whole picture.

That was why they mattered.

At 8:48, the laboratory obtained a warrant authorising comparison of the partial palm print from Markham's clinic with Pete Davidson's existing employment sample.

No informal look.

No verbal confirmation.

The examiner received coded files without names.

Elena read the order from a secure terminal in the adjoining federal building.

Desai stood behind her.

"Forty minutes," she said.

"If the ridge detail is sufficient."

"And if it matches?"

"It proves contact with the paper."

"Not when."

"Not why."

The answer remained deliberately small.

The independent team had already established that Pete received a discovery copy of the abstract two days earlier through counsel. His lawful copy carried a red footer and a unique page code.

The sheet recovered from Markham's printer did not.

It reproduced the archive version before the corrective audit was attached.

Pete's possession of one version could not explain his print on another without more evidence.

It also did not prove murder.

At 9:03, the first jury panel entered.

Thirty-six people.

Most looked towards Michael before they looked towards the judge.

One woman recognised him and stopped half a step inside the door.

The deputy directed her to the second row.

Solis explained that the case involved allegations of homicide, unlawful confinement, evidence manipulation and obstruction. She did not describe Michael as The Curator. The indictment contained acts, dates and names.

The public had supplied the identity.

The court attempted to remove it long enough for jurors to answer questions.

"Have any of you formed an opinion about whether Mr. Thorne is guilty?"

Twenty-two hands rose.

Michael watched the hands rather than the faces.

Price noticed.

"Do not count them," he whispered.

"I am not."

"You are placing them."

Michael lowered his eyes to the empty legal pad.

The prosecutor began asking whether jurors could separate proof of one charged act from evidence about another.

The question applied to more than the indictment.

Three floors below, Wells met the Markham case team in a room without windows.

A scene diagram covered one wall.

No photographs of the body.

The bottles.

The coat.

The printer.

The cheap watch.

The black card.

Wells studied spacing measurements while the homicide lieutenant explained the preliminary findings.

"The sedative patch delivered dexmedetomidine with a second compound that suppressed respiratory response. Medical examiner says the combination was prepared, not commercially issued."

"Source?"

"Unknown. Markham's clinic stocked neither. One hospital connected to his practice stocked the first drug. The second came from veterinary use."

"Access list?"

"Being built."

"Do not begin with officers connected to Thorne. Begin with everyone who could obtain both compounds."

The lieutenant nodded.

Wells pointed towards the watch.

"Retail?"

"Tourist shop near Navy Pier. Cash sale. They sold twenty-eight of the same model last month."

"Card stock?"

"Common art board. Hand-cut. The word was printed with a portable thermal unit."

"Anything uncommon?"

"The printer abstract. The credential route. The partial palm."

"Then those are the facts. The rest is resemblance."

At 9:41, the comparison result arrived.

The partial palm print was consistent with Pete Davidson.

Eleven corresponding ridge characteristics.

Enough for the examiner to report an identification under laboratory standards.

Not enough to state when the contact occurred.

Elena read the report twice.

No satisfaction.

No surprise she allowed herself to name.

"Notify his attorney," Desai said. "Request voluntary surrender of travel documents and devices while the warrant

application is prepared. Do not approach him at home until surveillance confirms who is there."

Pete was not at home.

The team watching his apartment had seen no movement since 5:18.

His car remained in the underground garage.

His phone was turned off.

The suspension order required him to report his location each morning by nine.

No report had arrived.

The fact moved him from interview subject to missing officer with evidence connecting him to a homicide scene.

It did not yet make him the killer.

Elena called Pete's attorney.

The man answered on the second ring.

"Detective Martinez, I assume this is no longer administrative."

"A laboratory comparison identifies Mr. Davidson's palm print on a document recovered at Dr. Markham's clinic. We need to know whether you are in contact with him."

Silence.

"He sent me an email at six twelve," the attorney said.

"Contents?"

"He terminated representation."

"Did he explain why?"

"He wrote that continued counsel would force me to protect a version I knew was incomplete."

"Forward it through the warrant team. Preserve headers. Do not reply."

"Am I being directed by police?"

"You are being notified that your former client may be at risk or connected to an active homicide. Your own obligations are yours."

The attorney exhaled.

"He left a package."

Elena looked towards Desai.

"Where?"

"Reception desk in my building. Addressed to Judge Solis. Security called me five minutes ago."

"Do not touch it. Evacuate the immediate area."

The bomb team reached the office at 10:16.

The package contained no explosive, chemical or electronic component.

Inside lay Pete's personal telephone, his suspended service weapon with the magazine removed and a handwritten inventory of every item.

No police badge.

No passport.

No medical courier credential.

A single page had been folded around the weapon.

I WILL NOT ASK AN ATTORNEY TO CALL THE RECORD COMPLETE.

The sentence did not confess to killing Markham.

It rejected the role of defendant before any charge existed.

At 10:32, the court recessed jury selection after a prospective juror said she had received a news alert about a new Curator murder.

Solis sent the panel out.

Price requested an inquiry into whether the alert contaminated the remaining jurors.

The prosecutor agreed.

No one argued the court could make the outside case disappear.

Michael leaned towards Price.

"Who is missing?"

Price kept his voice low.

"I cannot discuss the investigation."

"The juror said new murder. The court stopped before asking whether the defendant was contained. That means the fact is dangerous in both directions."

"Stop."

"They have a person."

"You do not know that."

"They have an officer."

Price looked at him.

Michael did not smile.

"What did you give Pete?" Price asked.

"The court opened the envelope."

"That is not what I asked."

Michael looked towards the empty jury box.

"I gave him a way to recognise when a case had been reduced to the version most useful to the institution."

"You gave him case abstracts with facts removed."

"And a written instruction not to treat them as proof."

"You also used the word remove."

"Access."

"Sometimes a person holds the access."

Michael's eyes moved to him.

Price had used Michael's own answer.

"Did you expect him to kill?" Price asked.

"No."

"Did you expect him to choose people?"

Michael took too long.

"I expected him to decide whether the record justified further inquiry."

"Outside any authorised investigation."

"After I became unavailable."

"You prepared a private continuation process."

"I prepared a test."

"For whom?"

Michael looked at the courtroom camera.

"For the person who believed my arrest ended the method."

Price closed his notebook.

"That is still not a name."

At 11:07, the Markham team entered Pete's apartment under warrant.

No person inside.

No blood.

No sedatives.

The bed had not been slept in.

On the kitchen table lay a printed copy of Naomi Sloane's candidate notice.

The corrective attachment describing her preservation work had been removed.

Beneath it, someone had drawn a rectangular box around her current address.

Not a Curator composition.

A target.

CHAPTER 2

THE METHOD HE WITHHELD

* * *

Price did not tell Michael that Naomi Sloane's address had been marked.

He told him the court had authorised a sealed safety conference and that any statement Michael made could affect both the active investigation and his defence.

"Then this is not privileged," Michael said.

"Our consultation is privileged. Information you direct me to transmit may not remain so."

"They want a prediction."

"They want facts about any danger you created."

Michael sat behind the steel table in the detention legal room.

Two cameras recorded the door and the empty space behind Price. Neither recorded sound until both men signed the limited-waiver form.

Price placed the form between them.

"The prosecution will not agree to use immunity. Judge Solis will permit a sealed proffer. She has not ruled whether statements may later be used if they reveal planning, intent or another offence."

"So the safe choice is silence."

"The legally protected choice is silence. Safety may require something else."

Michael read the form.

"Who is at risk?"

"I am not authorised to identify anyone."

"Then they are asking me to open a method without showing the input."

"You built the method."

"And they want to preserve the defence that I built it without intending the result."

"I want to preserve every defence the evidence allows."

Michael looked up.

"That is a different sentence."

"Yes."

Price had stopped promising to preserve Michael's preferred explanation.

The change mattered more than anger would have.

Michael signed the form.

The sound recorder activated.

Price stated the time, location and scope.

"Mr. Thorne, did you design the unseen-reader packet recovered from Officer Davidson's locker?"

"I wrote the letter and abstracts. I supplied route names for the credential. I did not encode the card."

"Why was Pete Davidson's badge number entered as the designated reader?"

"Because he had already demonstrated the relevant bias."

"What bias?"

"He believed institutional failure was evidence that a private conclusion had moral value."

"That sounds like your philosophy."

"It is one part of it without the restraint he thought he understood."

"What restraint?"

Michael looked at the blank wall.

"The subject had to possess an available corrective act and refuse it after recognising the harm."

Price did not move.

"That condition does not appear in the letter."

"It appears in the comparison column. Observable failure. Available response."

"Those words do not say a person must recognise harm."

"The reader was expected to verify it."

"How?"

"Contact. Surveillance. A controlled disclosure."

"Without lawful authority."

"Yes."

The admission entered the recording without qualification.

"Did you perform controlled disclosures before your own killings?"

Michael's eyes returned to Price.

"Sometimes."

"How many times?"

"That question concerns charged conduct."

"It also concerns how to recognise what Pete may do next."

Michael remained silent.

Price waited.

The recorder made no sound except a faint motor inside the table unit.

"Markham received a corrective fact," Michael said eventually.

Price had not told him.

"How do you know?"

"Because the first abstract omitted the pharmacy audit. Pete would not act until he saw the omission. Once he saw it, he had two options. Attach the audit and close the packet. Or decide the clearance answered the wrong question."

"Which did he choose?"

"If Markham is dead, the second."

"You predicted the victim from one name."

"I selected the names."

"That sentence is dangerous for you."

"It was true before I said it."

Price wrote nothing.

"What would Pete do after Markham?"

"Not repeat the scene."

"Why?"

"Because repetition would make him a copycat. He does not believe he is copying. He believes he is completing the part I abandoned when I allowed the court to become the reader."

"What part?"

"Judgement."

Price held his gaze.

"Name the next person."

Michael closed his eyes once.

Not a blackout.

A decision about sequence.

"Naomi Sloane."

"Basis?"

"Second abstract. Stronger contradiction. She processed corrected death certificates and later preserved originals. Pete will ask whether preservation after harm is correction or self-protection."

"Does he know where she lives?"

"The candidate notices were distributed. He may have seen the service record during administrative review."

"Did you give him an address?"

"No."

"A place?"

"The abstract referenced the county records division."

"Current?"

"No."

Price paused the recorder and called the sealed line.

He transmitted only the name and the stated basis.

Elena's answer came through the speaker.

"Sloane is not at her protected residence. Her phone stopped moving at 9:26. We found the notice in Davidson's apartment."

Michael did not react visibly.

Price restarted the recording.

"Where would he take her?"

"That depends on what he wants witnessed."

"You said he would not repeat the scene."

"Markham was a verdict. Naomi will be a hearing."

"Location."

"He needs a room that looks official after the authority is removed."

"That describes hundreds of buildings."

"A hearing room no longer used. Records nearby. Separate entrance. A place where a person can be both witness and subject."

Price looked towards the speaker.

Elena did not interrupt.

"Did you use such a place?" he asked.

Michael's jaw tightened.

"Yes."

"Where?"

"The old municipal appeals suite above the West Harrison records annex."

"For whom?"

"Not Naomi."

"Who?"

"A source in the Gabriel Shaw investigation."

"Name."

"Protected in the severed materials."

"You are invoking protection after naming the building."

"The person is alive."

"Because you spared them?"

"Because they gave me what I wanted."

No dissociation entered the sentence.

No Curator.

Michael used his own pronoun.

Price glanced at the recorder.

The defence strategy had depended on distinguishing episodes of impaired integration from deliberate conduct. The statement did not erase that distinction.

It showed Michael could use the method without losing capacity.

"Why would Pete know the location?" Price asked.

"He drove me there during a training detail two years later. I told him the building demonstrated how authority survives a closed office."

"Did he enter?"

"No."

"Then how does he know the room layout?"

"I described it."

Price's face changed.

Not surprise.

Recognition of how many ordinary conversations had been preparation.

"What did you describe?"

"Two entrances. A witness enclosure. An evidence lift. No active cameras after the county moved appeals hearings online."

"Enough to use it."

"Enough to recognise it."

"You keep replacing action with recognition."

"Because recognition is what I trained."

"And what did you believe recognition would produce?"

Michael looked at the sealed speaker.

Elena could hear him.

That altered the answer, but did not create it.

"A person who could continue an investigation if I was removed."

"Outside law."

"Outside a system I believed would bury the evidence with me."

"Did you believe Pete might kill?"

"I believed he wanted the moral clarity of the result more than the burden of producing it."

"That is not no."

"No."

The answer came late.

Price did not improve it for him.

"Did you select Pete because you thought he could become violent?"

"I selected him because he admired decisions he had never been required to make."

"And you wanted to require one."

"I wanted to know what he was."

"You made people into a test for that question."

Michael remained still.

"Yes."

The word damaged more than the defence.

It damaged the explanation that the packet had been only about preserving evidence.

Through the speaker, Elena said, "We are moving on West Harrison. We will verify independently before entry."

Michael leaned towards the unit.

"Do not use the main stair."

"Why?"

"The evidence lift opens behind the witness enclosure. If Pete restored power, the main stair will force the entry team into the hearing room before they see the rear corridor."

"Is that from memory or prediction?"

"Both."

"What else?"

"The old clerk's office has a mechanical document shutter. It can lock from the hearing-room side."

"Anything designed to harm responders?"

"Not when I used it."

"That is not what I asked."

Michael looked down at his hands.

"Pete prefers a decision that appears voluntary. He will not build a device that removes Naomi's choice. He may build one that makes every option harmful."

Elena's voice remained level.

"That is a hypothesis."

"Yes."

"We will treat it as one."

The speaker disconnected.

Price stopped the recording.

For several seconds neither man spoke.

Then Price removed the signed waiver form.

"The prosecution will argue that you consciously developed the same method years before the charged acts."

"They already have the packet."

"The packet was ambiguous. You just supplied intent."

"I supplied purpose."

"A jury may not preserve that distinction."

Michael looked towards the dark camera dome.

"Naomi may be alive because I supplied it."

"Yes."

"Then the statement was necessary."

Price placed the form inside his case.

"Necessary for her is not exculpatory for you."

Michael's face remained controlled.

The loss reached him anyway.

For the first time, helping the investigation had not allowed him to improve the story of why he had built the danger.

The recorder had preserved both.

CHAPTER 3

COUNT TWO

* * *

Naomi Sloane woke inside a witness box that no longer belonged to a court.

The glass reached from the table to the ceiling.

A microphone stood in front of her, its red light on despite the dust along the base. Beyond the glass, six empty chairs faced a raised desk where no judge sat.

Her wrists were free.

Her right ankle was secured to the chair by a padded restraint.

A document lay beneath the microphone.

CERTIFICATE OF CORRECTED DEATH.

The name printed across it belonged to an eleven-year-old boy Naomi had never met.

She had typed the correction thirty-one years earlier.

The door opened behind the raised desk.

Pete Davidson entered carrying a grey evidence box.

Naomi recognised him from television.

Younger officer.

Michael Thorne's admirer.

Suspended after hiding an envelope.

The public version contained enough truth to identify him and not enough to explain why he stood there.

"Are you police?" she asked.

Pete placed the box on the desk.

"Not today."

"Then unlock the restraint."

"After the record is complete."

"There is no record."

He looked at the red light.

"There is always a record."

Naomi did not look towards the camera she assumed was hidden behind the clerk's wall.

"What do you want me to say?"

"Nothing I provide."

"You brought a death certificate."

"You created it."

"I processed an order."

Pete opened the evidence box.

Inside stood three files.

White.

Blue.

Black.

He removed the white file first.

"This contains the order you received. Judge's signature. Medical affidavit. Guardianship notice. All valid in form."

"Not in fact."

"When did you know?"

Naomi looked at the certificate.

"Not that day."

"When?"

"Months later."

"How many corrections did you process before you knew?"

"I do not know."

"You preserved seventeen."

"I preserved what I could prove."

"After how many?"

She looked at him.

The question carried no curiosity.

He knew the available answer was incomplete.

"Forty-two requests passed through the division," she said.
"Some were clerical. Some were ordinary adoptions. Some were witness-protection substitutions I was not authorised to examine. Seventeen matched the same sponsor code."

"You kept copies."

"Yes."

"Why not report them?"

"I did."

"To whom?"

"My supervisor."

"Who closed it."

"Yes."

"Then?"

"County counsel."

"Who referred it back."

"Yes."

"Then?"

Naomi looked at the black file.

"I had a daughter."

Pete's expression did not change.

"That is context."

"It is the answer."

"It explains fear. It does not explain the children who remained dead on paper."

"Nothing explains them."

"Then why should preservation count as correction?"

Naomi understood the hearing.

He had not brought her to establish what she did.

He had brought her to decide whether what she later did had enough moral weight to keep her alive.

"Who judged Dr. Markham?" she asked.

Pete's eyes moved towards the microphone.

"He was given the missing fact."

"And you killed him after he read it."

Pete did not answer.

The silence answered enough.

Naomi's fear became physical then.

Cold along both arms.

A tightening beneath her ribs.

She kept her voice steady because the person in front of her admired control.

"Michael Thorne prepared my file."

"Part of it."

"Did he tell you to bring me here?"

"No."

"Then you are not continuing him."

Pete removed the blue file.

"This contains the copies you preserved."

"Where did you get them?"

"The court's protected inventory identifies their existence. It does not reproduce them."

"That was not my question."

"A former clerk retained duplicates."

"Name."

"The name is not relevant to your act."

Naomi almost laughed.

"You hide your source while trying me for not exposing mine."

Pete's face tightened.

Not anger.

The physical response of a structure forced out of alignment.

"My source is not the subject."

"Neither were the children when I processed the papers. That was the language. The applicant was the subject. The child was the record."

He remained still.

Naomi continued.

"You think categories protect the question from becoming personal. They do not. They only decide who is allowed to speak."

Pete opened the black file.

It contained one blank sheet.

"This is the current finding."

"Already decided?"

"No."

"Then why am I restrained?"

"Because leaving before the evidence is tested would make the process meaningless."

"A process I did not consent to."

"Neither did the children."

He believed the parallel justified him.

Naomi saw that clearly.

Not madness.

Not confusion.

A moral conclusion arranged to remove his own position from the frame.

"What is the test?" she asked.

Pete took a small metal box from beneath the desk.

Two switches stood on top.

PRESERVE.

CORRECT.

A timer displayed twenty-three minutes.

"One switch sends the preserved copies to the court's protected server," he said. "The other replaces the existing public death entries with the children's original names."

Naomi stared at him.

"You cannot do that."

"The routes are prepared."

"The original names belong to living people under protection. Publishing them could kill them."

"Then choose preserve."

"And what happens?"

"The current legal identities remain. The original children remain dead in the public record."

"Both switches harm them."

"That is what you accepted thirty-one years ago."

"No. That is what the system did before the choice reached my desk."

"You processed it."

"Yes."

Naomi looked at the timer.

"What happens if I choose neither?"

"The last selected route executes."

"Which one?"

"You do not know."

The uncertainty was the coercion.

He had not removed choice.

He had removed any safe choice, then planned to call the result voluntary.

Naomi leaned towards the microphone.

"My name is Naomi Sloane. I processed corrected death certificates under orders I later learned were part of an unlawful identity programme. I reported the pattern through two official channels. Both failed. I preserved copies without authorisation. I did not contact the families because I was afraid and because I did not know which disclosure would

expose the children. That failure belongs to me. It does not give you authority over them now."

Pete watched her.

"That is not a selection."

"It is a statement."

"The route will still execute."

"Then you choose it."

The timer showed nineteen minutes.

Pete moved around the desk.

For the first time, Naomi saw strain in the way he carried his left shoulder.

He had been awake too long.

Or injured.

Human details entered the room and made him more dangerous, not less.

"Michael said people reveal themselves when the available response costs them something," Pete said.

"Michael is on trial."

"Because the court saw the result and not the failures he corrected."

"He killed people."

"Some."

The word contained admiration and disappointment at once.

Naomi understood then that Pete did not want to prove Michael innocent.

He wanted to prove Michael's guilt had been a form of competence.

A method the court could condemn and still need.
A sound moved behind the wall.
Metal against metal.
Pete turned his head.
Not towards the main door.
Towards the evidence lift.
Naomi did not look.
The timer continued.
Pete removed a small pistol from beneath his coat.
Not his suspended service weapon.
A compact black handgun with no visible police markings.
"Who did you call?" he asked.
"No one."
"Who knew you were coming?"
"You brought me."
The sentence broke his expected sequence.
For half a second he looked younger.
An officer waiting for the senior detective to tell him which detail mattered.
Then he recovered.
He moved towards the rear corridor.
The first federal entry team reached the building at 12:41.
They had not entered.
An engineer was tracing restored power while Elena and Desai reviewed the original plans from a county archive that had not been supplied by Michael.
The evidence lift showed current draw.

The main stair did not.

Michael's warning was independently verified.

Elena stood beside the service entrance in body armour while the tactical commander outlined the options.

"Rear corridor gives us the witness enclosure. Main stair gives us the hearing room. We do not know where Davidson is."

"Naomi?"

"Thermal shows one seated person in the enclosure. One moving between the bench and rear corridor."

"Any third?"

"No."

"Devices?"

"Wired box on the witness table. Connection leaves the room through old court conduit. Bomb technician cannot identify function remotely."

Desai looked at Elena.

"He may be able to execute remotely if he sees entry."

"Then isolate outgoing lines before movement."

"Cutting power may trigger it."

"Do not cut. Bridge and capture. Same method as legacy ingest."

The telecommunications engineer began working from the basement junction.

No one entered because Michael predicted a room.

They entered when the building records, thermal scan and line trace supported a plan.

At 12:48, the engineer redirected both outgoing routes into an isolated recorder.

The device inside would believe it had reached the protected server and public registry.

Neither destination would receive data.

The tactical commander raised one hand.

Elena's phone vibrated inside the armour pocket.

Price.

She did not answer.

The commander lowered his hand.

The evidence-lift door opened under remote mechanical control.

Two agents entered the rear corridor.

Pete saw the movement through a narrow glass panel.

He did not fire.

He stepped backwards into the hearing room and pressed a switch beneath the judge's desk.

The timer in front of Naomi dropped from fourteen minutes to thirty seconds.

She placed both hands flat on the table.

No switch.

No consent.

Pete looked through the glass at her.

"Choose."

Naomi leaned towards the microphone.

"You already did."

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continues beyond this excerpt.

The Michael Thorne Series - Book Six